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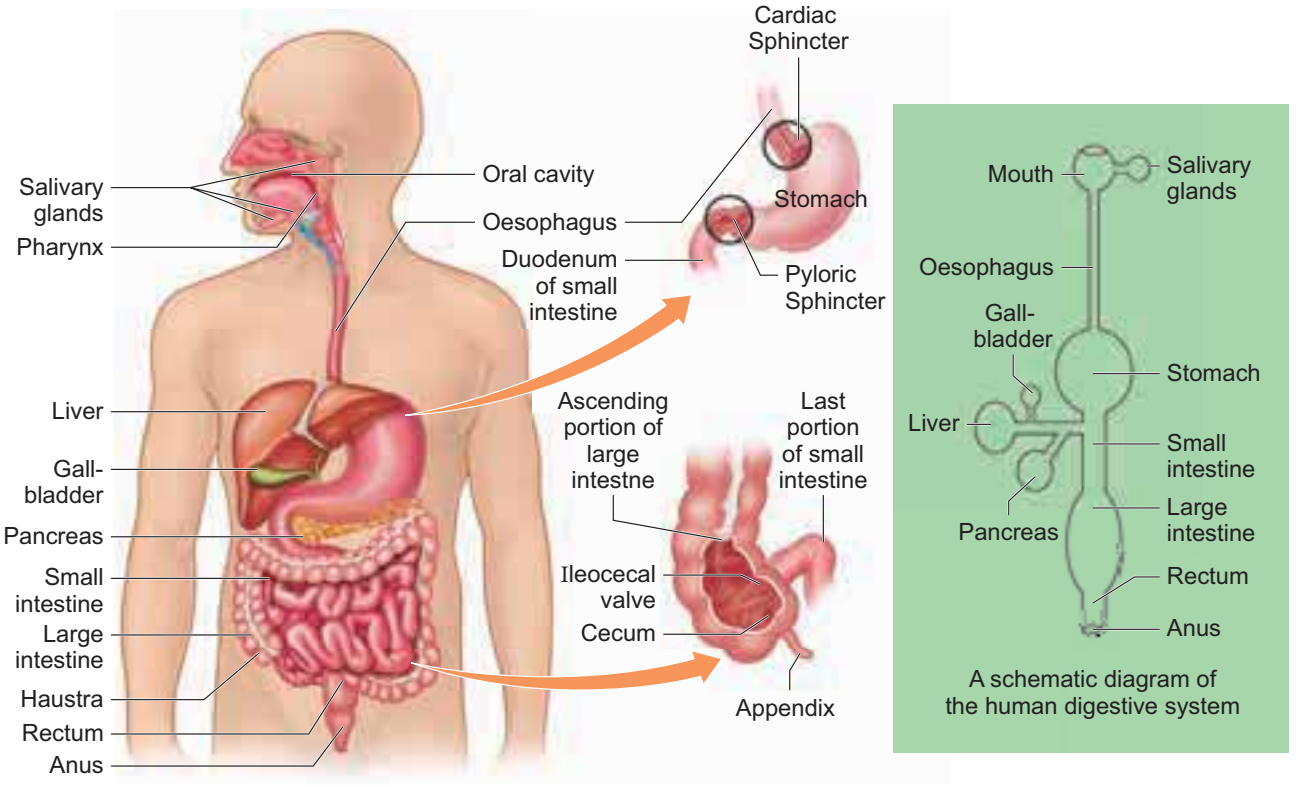


Figure 5.1 The Human Digestive system

food, chew and mix food with saliva, to swallow food and also to speak. The upper surface of the tongue has small projections called papillae with taste buds.

The oral cavity leads into a short common passage for food and air called pharynx. The oesophagus and the trachea (wind pipe) open into the pharynx. Food passes into the oesophagus through a wide opening called gullet at the back of the pharynx. A cartilaginous flap called epiglottis prevents the entry of food into the glottis (opening of trachea) during swallowing. Two masses of lymphoid tissue called tonsils are also located at the sides of the pharynx.

Oesophagus is a thin long muscular tube concerned with conduction of the food to a 'J' shaped stomach passing through the neck, thorax and diaphragm. A cardiac sphincter (gastro oesphageal sphincter) regulates the opening of oesophagus into the stomach (Figure. 5.1). If the cardiac sphincter does not contract properly during the churning action of the stomach the gastric juice with acid may flow back into the oesophagus and cause heart burn, resulting in **GERD** (Gastero Oesophagus Reflex Disorder).

The stomach functions as the temporary storage organ for food and is located in the upper left portion of the abdominal cavity. It consists of three parts – a cardiac portion into which the oesophagus opens; a fundic portion and a pyloric portion that opens into the duodenum. The opening of the stomach into the duodenum is guarded by the pyloric sphincter. It periodically allows partially digested food to enter the duodenum and also prevents regurgitation of food. The inner wall of stomach has many folds called **gastric rugae** which unfolds to accommodate a large meal.